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GALAXY TYPES

1 Spiral galaxy
At 21 million light-years away, the Pinwheel Galaxy (M101) is relatively close to Earth. It is also roughly 50 percent bigger than the Milky Way, making it is one of the few galaxies in which individual regions can be studied. The Pinwheel has an extensive system of spiral arms. It appears lopsided, with the core, or nucleus, offset from the true centre, probably as a result interactions with other galaxies in the past.

2 Barred spiral galaxy
This galaxy, NGC 1300, is considered the prototype of the barred spiral galaxy. Instead of spiralling all the way to the central nucleus, the galaxy's two spiral arms are instead connected to each other by a straight bar of stars that includes the nucleus. This detailed Hubble Space Telescope image reveals that the nucleus has its own spiral structure. Gas in the bar is funneled inwards before spiraling into the nucleus.

3 Elliptical galaxy
Apart from a simple ball shape, elliptical galaxies show little structure. Giant ellipticals such as IC 2006, shown here in an image taken in visible light by the Hubble Space Telescope, initially formed billions of years ago and are thought to have grown larger as they absorbed satellite galaxies. Due to its age, IC 2006 is made up of old, low-mass stars and there is no, or minimal, star formation activity.

4 Lenticular galaxy
This type of galaxy is named after its overall lenslike, or "lenticular" shape. NGC 2787 is one of the closest lenticular galaxies to Earth. This visible-light image shows tightly wound, almost concentric lanes of dust encircling the galaxy's bright nucleus. Several bright blobs of light can be seen on the edge of the galaxy. Each of these is, in fact, a cluster of several hundred thousand stars orbiting NGC 2787.